KZ PERSPECTIVES | 08

Culture is an Outcome, Not an Initiative

Why *Culture takes shape through everyday decisions and behaviour.*

The culture people experience

Ask leaders to describe their organization's culture and they may point to its values, its ambitions and the behaviours they hope to encourage. Ask employees, and you may hear something more immediate: what happens in meetings, how decisions are made, whether problems can be raised openly and how people are treated when things go wrong.

Both perspectives matter. But the culture employees experience each day is a useful test of whether the culture leaders describe actually exists.

This is why culture cannot be changed through workshops, value statements or posters alone. Those may help express an ambition. **The culture itself takes shape through the way work gets done.**

A poster above the plant manager's desk

During one of my assignments, I visited a factory in a European business I was leading. Above the plant manager's desk hung a large poster of a burning forest.

I asked him about it. He explained that he spent his days putting out fires—and felt he had become rather good at it.

The poster stayed with me because it captured the way the plant was operating. Problems were handled as they arose, but there was no sufficiently clear plan for addressing their causes or setting a direction for the factory. People complained about a lack of resources. Engagement was low, and the team had little reason to believe things would improve.

We could have called this a "culture problem" and have launched an initiative to encourage greater ownership. But asking people to take ownership would have meant little while they lacked a credible plan and a meaningful part in carrying it out.

Change the work, and culture can follow

We changed the plant's leadership and introduced a more structured way of working. New leaders helped develop practical improvement programmes, with people from the factory floor involved in shaping plans they could execute.

Progress took time. As team members began to see the results of their work, however, their engagement changed. They could say, with justification, "I was part of this." Ownership and pride grew from that experience.

Before the changes, the prevailing culture was reactive. People expected the next problem, complained about what they lacked and had little confidence that they could influence the factory's direction. As the new way of working took hold, that began to shift. People helped

solve problems rather than simply respond to them. They could see the results of their efforts and take pride in what the plant was becoming.

The factory's performance improved substantially. We had not started by asking people to adopt a new set of cultural adjectives. We had changed the conditions in which they worked, and over time, the culture they experienced changed too.

Daily conditions shape people's behaviour

When leaders want to change the culture, it is worth looking first at the conditions people face every day.

Culture does not simply follow an announcement. It develops through repeated experience. Changing how an organisation leads, decides and works together gives people a different experience—and, over time, a reason to describe its culture differently.

Perhaps we should ask ourselves:

- Are our priorities clear, and can people make the decisions needed to act on them?
- Do teams have the support to solve recurring problems?
- Are people involved in changes that affect their work?
- What culture are our everyday actions creating?